

08 Narrative tenses

When telling a story, even if you're just talking about something that happened recently, you need to use a variety of tenses so that the story can be understood easily.

⚙️ New language The past perfect continuous

Aa Vocabulary Travel adjectives and idioms

🧩 New skill Talking about a variety of past actions

8.1 KEY LANGUAGE NARRATIVE TENSES

You can use different past tenses to show when past actions or states overlap, or to say which took place first.

PAST SIMPLE

The past simple describes actions or states that happened in a specific finished time period.

**Last summer, we flew to London.
There's so much to do there!**

A specific finished time period ("last summer") is specified, so the past simple is used.

PAST CONTINUOUS

The past continuous describes an action that began before, and possibly continued after, another past action.

**While we *were walking* around the city,
we took some photos in front of Big Ben.**

You often use the past simple and the past continuous together to say that one action interrupted a longer one.

PAST PERFECT

The past perfect describes an action or state that happened before something else in the past.

This action happened before something else in the past (the trip abroad), so the past *perfect* is used.

**Fortunately, we *had looked up* all
the best places to go beforehand.**



NOW

